Alto HSR: Multimodal Corridor Opportunity

The F1 cycle highway in Belgium follows a HSR TEN-T railroad line. Photo credit: ECF

A practical opportunity exists to enhance the Alto High-Speed Rail (HSR) project by incorporating a parallel all-season multimodal pathway (bike, walk, run, ski, etc) within the corridor. This approach is supported by international precedent and directly addresses key stakeholder concerns raised across the corridor. It transforms the project from a single-purpose rail line into a nation-building, community-serving active transportation corridor.

Rail corridors are uniquely suited for active transportation: they are direct, low-gradient, and connect communities. European policy bodies recommend integrating multimodal pathways, and bicycle-friendly trains and station infrastructure, into major transport corridors from the outset to avoid costly retrofits and missed opportunities.

Alto represents a rare opportunity to integrate multimodal infrastructure from the beginning.

Addressing Current Stakeholder Concerns

- Local Benefit Gap: Provides tangible local value even where no station exists. Trail users will take advantage of local amenities and provide opportunities for local tourism.
- Community Severance: A parallel pathway restores local connectivity across a fenced rail corridor. Shared bridges and accesses allow for local crossings of the HSR line.
- Trail Loss (e.g., Prescott–Russell): Preserves and enhances existing trail networks.
- Health and Environmental Concerns: Encourages active transport and can incorporate wildlife crossings.
- Consultation & Trust: Demonstrates responsiveness to community input and proactive planning.

Evidence from Practice

• Hundreds of 'rail-with-trail' projects exist globally alongside active rail lines[1].
• Trails operate safely alongside rail with proper setbacks, fencing, and crossings.
• European ECF TEN-T policy explicitly recommends integrating multimodal trails into transport corridors[2].
• Belgium's F1 and F3 cycle highways demonstrate successful co-location.

Recommended Next Steps

1. Include multimodal pathway in the corridor design.
2. Include bicycle-friendly trains and station infrastructure into the corridor design.
3. Engage cycling, trail groups, municipal, and environmental stakeholders in a corridor working group.

Conclusion

Integrating a multimodal pathway into Alto is low-risk, evidence-based, and directly responsive to stakeholder concerns. It transforms the project from a single-purpose rail line into a nation-building, community-serving transportation corridor.

Contact: altomultimodalpathway@lumply.ca
https://altomultimodalpathway.github.io/AltoMultiModalCorridor/

[1] https://railroads.dot.gov/elibrary/rails-trails-best-practices-and-lessons-learned-0

[2] https://www.ecf.com/media/resources/2021/TEN-T_ECF_Position_Paper_2020-2.pdf